Give Trust Freely. Your Team's Productivity Depends On It.

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Quick Bridge

Conventional wisdom says trust is earned. People prove themselves first. Then you increase their responsibility and access slowly. But there is a cost to that approach that most teams never see. **The opposite strategy — giving trust first, then withdrawing it only for specific behaviors — creates faster learning, higher ownership, and teams that actually want to show up to work.**

The True Cost of "Earned Trust"

Most teams operate on a trust-as-currency model. You watch. You wait. You see if people follow through on small things first. Gradually, over months, you give them more responsibility.

It feels safe. You are not surprised. People have to prove themselves first.

The cost is invisible until you see it.

When people feel they are not trusted yet, everything slows down. They ask permission instead of taking initiative. They do not bring you early-stage problems because they assume it will hurt their standing. They wait for instructions instead of making decisions. Feedback stays bottled up.

Skip-level meetings fall apart because no one trusts that raising a concern will not damage their relationship with their direct manager. The people you hired to think independently start asking "is this okay?" for decisions they should own.

And here is the irony: when you eventually do grant them trust, it does not feel like trust. It feels like a reward they had to earn. So when they eventually fail, it feels like betrayal from both sides.

Why This Model Persists (Even When It Costs Money)

The earned-trust model persists because it feels protective. If you wait to see performance before trusting, you cannot be surprised. You are in control.

But control is not the same as leadership.

Korn Ferry research found that 22% of organizational financial performance is directly tied to trust in senior leadership. High-trust companies show 50% more productivity, 106% more energy, and 76% more engagement from their teams.

That is not correlation. That is causation. Trust is not nice. It is business.

- Yet we keep running teams as if trust is something people have to earn through months of observation. And then we wonder why:
- Burnout is epidemic among leaders (who are managing everyone as if they cannot be trusted)
- Technical talent leaves (they get tired of being monitored)
- Initiatives take twice as long (because people are waiting for permission)
- Skip-level concerns explode (because the direct report is afraid to bring problems to their manager)

The model was never about safety. It was about the leader's fear.

The Inversion: What Happens When You Give Trust First

What if you flipped it?

What if the starting position was trust? Not blind trust. Not trust in every dimension. Just a baseline assumption that people are capable and well-intentioned.

Then, when specific behaviors do not align, you withdraw trust in that specific area.

You do not withdraw trust from the person. You redirect the behavior.

This changes everything.

When I gave my direct report information early, I was saying: I trust you with this information. I trust that you can handle uncertainty. I trust that you want the team to succeed.

What I was managing was the specific behavior of how they communicated that uncertainty to others.

I did that management by changing when and how they got the information. Not by shutting them out. Not by treating them as untrustworthy. By giving them a structure that helped them succeed.

It sounds backwards. But the outcomes are different immediately.

People step into ownership. They bring you problems earlier because you already showed them you will not shoot the messenger. They are honest in your 1-on-1s because they are not defending a position. They are sharing a reality.

The Mechanics: How Trust Actually Works at Scale

Trust is not all-or-nothing. It is granular. You can trust someone with technical decisions while you are still building trust in their customer communication. You can trust their project ownership while you are developing their hiring judgment.

This is where most leaders get it wrong. They think trust is a single currency. It is not.

Start by being explicit about what you are actually trusting them with. Say it out loud. Not "I trust you" in the abstract. Specific: "I trust you to make technical decisions on this project. I trust you to own the customer relationship. I trust you to escalate blockers when you see them."

Then, when a behavior shows that withdrawal is needed, name the behavior, not the person.

Do not say: "I can't trust you with this."

Instead: "This situation requires a different approach than what you chose. Here is what I need to see going forward."

One attacks their judgment. The other redirects their action. Both create accountability. Only one makes people want to keep trying.

The Information Gap: Why Sharing Early Matters More Than You Think

Teams that operate on high trust share information earlier. Not after official announcements. Not after decisions are locked. Before.

This solves a problem you do not see until you fix it: the information gap between what you know and what your team knows creates three separate realities.

In your reality, you are thinking through a decision. In your team's reality, you disappeared into meetings and came back with conclusions that feel arbitrary. And in your skip-level's reality, your direct report is scrambling to interpret what is happening.

When you share early, you collapse those gaps. Your team sees the thinking. Not the finished answer. The actual thinking.

Do this with skip-level meetings. Bring them context before it is official. Share the problem you are trying to solve. Share what you are uncertain about. Let them process it while you are there.

If they overreact in private, that is processing. That is healthy. That is what trust looks like in action.

What This Unlocks

Here is what happens when you operate this way.

People take more ownership. They are not waiting for permission that feels like it is never coming. They escalate problems earlier. They make decisions they should be making. They bring you early-stage thinking instead of waiting until it is polished or broken.

Feedback stops getting bottled up. Skip-level conversations become real. People tell you what is actually happening instead of what they think you want to hear.

And when you do need to hold someone accountable, it does not feel like betrayal. It feels like a course correction. Because the trust was real. You gave it. You are just redirecting where behavior needs to shift.

This is the difference between a team that works for you and a team that works with you.

The Monday Action

Identify one person on your team you have been cautious about. One specific area where you could give them more trust. Not their whole role. One piece.

Share that explicitly with them this week: "I want to give you more trust with X. This is important to us. I am going to start including you in earlier conversations so you have full context."

Then let them prove what you already believe.

One More Thing

The leaders who struggle most with this are the ones running scared. They have been burned before. They have managed someone who broke their trust. And now they carry that story into every relationship.

But that is the trap. One person's failure does not mean everyone is broken. And treating everyone like they might break your trust is what actually breaks teams.

Give trust. Withdraw it specifically when needed. But give it.

Your Turn

Think about the last person who gave you trust before you had to earn it. How did that change how you showed up?

You're great at the work. Let's make you impossible to ignore.

If you are looking for help building a team culture where people step into trust rather than waiting for permission, consider reaching out.

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Impact Labels

Peer leadership, Manager burnout

External References

- **Korn Ferry Research on Trust and Performance:** Studies show that trust in senior leadership accounts for 22% of organizational financial performance. High-trust companies see 50% higher productivity, 106% greater energy, and 76% more employee engagement than low-trust environments.
- **Psychological Safety in Teams:** The work of Amy Edmondson (Harvard Business School) demonstrates that teams with high psychological safety — where members trust they can take interpersonal risks — consistently outperform teams without it.
- **Information Flow and Decision Quality:** Organizations that share information early in decision-making processes see faster implementation and higher team buy-in than those that withhold context until announcements are final.